

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-06-30

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 teaching activities in . . . , and we have been asked to convey the following
3 response to you. . . .

it is understandable that you feel concern about methods of teaching

4 which apply pressure to people to declare their faith in bahá'u'lláh, or which
5 register as believers those who apparently have no real knowledge of the faith or its
message. it troubles you that such methods of teaching seem to
6 be sanctioned by the institutions of the faith in . . . and that your remon-
7 strances have met with no satisfying response from those institutions.

The teaching of the cause has always called for wisdom, devotion, en-

8 thusiasm, purity of intention and eloquence of speech. like other human
9 beings, bahá'ís tend to go to extremes, and too few people bring the proper 162.1

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163 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

164 8balance to the way they act. This is particularly true in the teaching of the

165 faith. At one extreme are those who are so on fire with love for the faith and

166 with awareness of the desperate need of the people for its healing message, that they
overstep the bounds of wisdom and discretion and stray into the area of proselytizing. At the
other extreme are those who are so gentle in their approach and so concerned never to
arouse an adverse reaction that

167 they fail to convey the enormous importance of the cause or to convince

168 their hearers; for if the messenger is not enthusiastic, how can he convey

169 enthusiasm to others? The first extreme leads to misrepresentation of the teachings
and causes disillusionment; the second results in the stagnation of

170 the community and its failure to fulfill its fundamental duty of conveying

171 this life-giving message to the world.
 172 in this, as in all aspects of the work of the cause, the solution lies in
 173 the friends being patient and forbearing towards those whose shortcomings distress
 them, and in endeavoring, through the Assemblies' consultation, to draw closer to a proper
 balance while maintaining the momentum of the work and canalizing the enthusiasm of the
 believers.
 174 in one of its messages, published on page 32 of Wellspring of Guidance,
 175 the universal house of justice gave the following advice:

Those who declare themselves as bahá'ís should become enchanted

176 with the beauty of the teachings, and touched by the love of bahá'u'lláh. The
 declarants need not know all the proofs, history,
 177 laws, and principles of the faith, but in the process of declaring them-
 178 selves they must, in addition to catching the spark of faith, become basically informed
 about the central figures of the faith, as well as
 179 the existence of laws they must follow and an administration they must obey.

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181 in the western world in recent decades, bahá'ís have grown used to think-
 182 ing that the process by which a person accepts the faith takes a long time,
 183 and that it is unthinkable for someone to intelligently accept bahá'u'lláh
 184 within minutes of hearing of him. This may be the pattern to which they
 185 have become accustomed, but it is far from being a universal one. when
 186 people accepted the faith quickly in Africa and other parts of the Third

187 162-1. muhj, no. 18.4.162.4

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163 1993-1996 • The Three Year Plan

164 9world, western bahá'ís sometimes explained it away by saying that such
 165 people were less educated and had fewer ideas to work their way through.
 166 Now the same process is happening in the countries of the former eastern
 167 bloc, and highly educated people are accepting the faith as soon as they
 168 hear of it, embracing it enthusiastically, and rapidly deepening their un-

169 derstanding of its teachings by reading every bahá'í book they can lay their
170 hands on. So it is clear that receptivity to spiritual truth is, as bahá'u'lláh
171 indicated, a matter of purity of heart, not of education or lack of it.
172 in the west of europe, too, there are signs of greater receptivity towards
173 the faith among the people, and some are ready to join the community of

the most great Name if approached in the proper manner. in such cases

174 when an individual hears the message of bahá'u'lláh and is moved to declare
175 his faith, there should be no obstacle placed in his way. great care must
176 be taken that when the heart of the individual is touched by the power of
bahá'u'lláh's message and the declarant has expressed his desire to em-
177 brace the faith, the process of deepening be followed almost immediately.
178 deepening the knowledge of the new believer in the verities of the faith is
179 the most vital part of teaching; but deepening is not merely the imparting of
knowledge—it requires also to imbue the soul of the person with the love of bahá'u'lláh so
that his faith may grow day by day and he becomes a
180 steadfast believer.

181 in the following statement, Shoghi effendi advises the bahá'í teacher to
182 advance the process of deepening for a person who is attracted to the faith:

let him [the bahá'í teacher] consider the degree of his hearer's

183 receptivity, and decide for himself the suitability of either the direct or indirect
method of teaching, whereby he can impress upon the seeker the vital importance of the
divine message, and persuade him

to throw in his lot with those who have already embraced it. let him

remember the example set by 'Abdu'l-bahá, and his constant admoni-

184 tion to shower such kindness upon the seeker, and exemplify to such a degree the
spirit of the teachings he hopes to instill into him, that the

recipient will be spontaneously impelled to identify himself with the

cause embodying such teachings. let him refrain, at the outset, from

insisting on such laws and observances as might impose too severe a

strain on the seeker's newly awakened faith, and endeavor to nurse

185 him, patiently, tactfully, and yet determinedly, into full maturity, and aid him to
proclaim his unqualified acceptance of whatever has been 162.7

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50ordained by bahá'u'lláh. let him, as soon as that stage has been at-

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tained, introduce him to the body of his fellow-believers, and seek,

through constant fellowship and active participation in the local ac-

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tivities of his community, to enable him to contribute his share to the enrichment of its life, the furtherance of its tasks, the consolidations of its interests, and the coordination of its activities with those of its

sister communities. let him not be content until he has infused into

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his spiritual child so deep a longing as to impel him to arise indepen-

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dently, in his turn, and devote his energies to the quickening of other souls, and the upholding of the laws and principles laid down by his

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newly adopted faith.

(The Advent of Divine Justice, pp. 51–52)162-2

from these words of the guardian we can see that wisdom, encourage-

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ment, persuasion, and patience, are all called for, and that these must be attuned to the response shown by the hearer. we also see that the process of

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deepening continues long after the new believer has enrolled in the bahá'í

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community. . . .

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with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

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Personal Sacrifice in Giving to the Fund

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]